of her life.

They arrived at the station in less than ten minutes. At the platform, she fumbled with the tickets inside the envelope—there were so many different trains to take—until she finally found the ticket for Paris and handed it to the police officer checking documents.

But where was Rose?

“Papers, mademoiselle,” he said.

She passed him her identification card along with the letter from the German Employment Office. She glanced up, scanning the station, searching for her sister. The officer returned the documents and, with his hand, signaled to her to continue through the gate.

The sky was low and overcast. As Léa plunged her hands into her pockets to warm them, Rose came hurrying alongside her and the German soldier.

“Rose!” Léa felt almost heady with relief as they embraced. Léa pulled back first.

“I worried I wouldn’t see you before I left,” she said. “How did you get on the platform without a ticket?”

“Léa, I—”

A piercing screech stole Rose’s words as the train arrived. People surged forth to board it.

“Why did the man at the German Employment Office say that my signing bonus was given to Virginie? I want it to go to you.”

Rose took Léa by the arm and guided her quickly to the carriage matching the number on her ticket, the German escort still close behind. Rose carried their mother’s brown suitcase, bumping it against her leg as they walked. Léa noticed for the first time that Rose had slung the leather satchel containing her pencils and sketchbooks across her shoulder.

“Go on,” Rose said. “Up the stairs. I’ll follow with the suitcase.”

“I can carry it.” Léa reached for the case, but Rose held it back waiting for her to board first.

When Rose joined her in the carriage, Léa imagined her sister was lingering because she found it difficult to say goodbye. She wanted to talk to her about serious matters and let her know it might be years before they saw one another again.

“Do you know that the contract is now for an indefinite period?” Léa